financially and, as put by X, 'to only the bare minimum, just to keep their noses above the water.'[40] Most of this was done with X running the show from India's side, having developed a close rapport with Engineer Arif (Muhammad Arif Sarwari, Massoud's chief of intelligence) and his interpreter, Amrullah Saleh, who later led the Afghan intelligence services, the National Directorate of Security (NDS). In fact, X concedes that there was little overt political clearance for such covert activities during the Deve Gowda and Gujral governments, even if they agreed with the R&AW's approach. It was not until the entry of Brajesh Mishra as NSA in 1998 that India openly adopted an 'interventionist approach' in Afghanistan. While X refuses to give details of how he went about doing his business in cultivating links with the UF, he accepts that India was closest to Massoud and actively dealing with Dostum, who at that time was the *Amir* of north Afghanistan and had very close links with Russia and Uzbekistan. There was, however, more to India's role in its engagement with the UF. New Delhi was working as the communication system for these anti-Taliban commanders and tried hard to keep them all together under the UF umbrella. Says X:

> More than Iran and Russia, different Afghan factions understood us [India] well. India played a very important role in getting Dostum and Massoud together. Massoud was very unhappy with Dostum. We got the Shias and Dostum and Massoud together and gave money. We were looking for all anti-Taliban groups and trying to get them to work together.[41]

Indian spies conducted shuttle diplomacy between different UF factions to iron out their differences. Often leading to Massoud and Dostum targeting each other's senior aides, these rifts were potent enough to disintegrate the resistance to the Taliban. On 28 December 1999, for instance, when India was busy dealing with the IC-814 hijacking, Massoud's men allegedly killed Abdul Chereek, a senior aide of Dostum in Sar-e-Pul. It was big blow to Dostum.[42] Just when New Delhi's attention was diverted to the hijacking crisis, Massoud had struck. New Delhi tried limiting Massoud and Dostum's differences but was failing at doing so effectively on the ground. However, the results of this covert shuttle diplomacy were visible in the India-friendly Afghan cabinet that was instituted in 2002 after the entry of the coalition forces and ouster of the Taliban.

'Pakistan's Vietnam'